



PRAVEEN NEG

DELHI | Monitoring a Menace

Months after 19-year-old Amann Kachroo was ragged to death at a medical college in Himachal Pradesh, the Ministry of Human Resource Development has finally woken up. The ministry has initiated steps to set up a call centre that will receive complaints from students being ragged. A database of colleges across the country will be created to ensure swift response to complaints. If college authorities fail to deliver, the matter would be referred to the local police and administration. The system that the ministry plans to put in place focuses on "preventing students from being subjected to ragging rather than harping on past tragic events", says Rajendra Kachroo, Amann's father and the man who suggested the blueprint around which the new system is based. Rajendra also initiated the Amann Movement that calls for immediate steps to stop ragging based 'on prevention and monitoring' by an 'independent monitoring agency'. The agency in question would ensure speedy intervention at nine levels: starting from regulatory authorities to the political, parental and school levels. The blueprint suggests a nationwide, 24x7 call centre where anyone with relevant information about ragging can call or send an SMS to a toll-free number. It would also be used to keep a close eye on other problem areas such as alcoholism and drug abuse. Rajendra calls his blueprint a 'social reformist movement' using a 'technological approach'.

**KACHROO'S
FAMILY PAYS
HOMAGE AT A
CANDLELIGHT
PROTEST IN
NEW DELHI**

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by Mihir Srivastava